Community Involvement and Social Networking in a Cultural Heritage Organization in Norway

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During the past twenty years there has been considerable practical and theoretical interest in the relationship between heritage sites and communities (Stevens, Flinn & Shepherd 2010). This interest can be traced back to the promotion of community development ideas in the 1950s and 1960s, which was understood as an opportunity for the state to involve civil society in public policy (Crook 2007). In addition to create social practices that could cross institutional borders, communities has also become an ethical issue in the ICOM Code of Ethics – where museums are to be in service to community, respect its interest and work in close collaboration with communities "from which their collections originate" (Crook 2007). Museums' relation to communities – as well as the cultural heritage knowledge building that is going on inside communities outside of the museum institution creates interesting sites for understanding processes of the extended conceptions of cultural heritage.

We are facing many new initiatives of museums, archives and heritage institutions, profiling them as responsive, democratic, and reflective institutions that promote civil participation of communities actively (Stevens, Flinn and Shepherd 2010) and that plays an important role in taking `museum conversation` beyond the museum (Black 2010). The trends towards re-contextualising and re-localizing cultural heritage objects and knowledge has taken many and diverging forms and one of the results is the responsiveness museums has established to meet communities and the cultures they represent (Message 2006). Still, critical voices have been raised to challenge the museum in its relationship with the public and criticism has been raised on the grounds that museums are "floating above the community," claiming museums are not as hospitable as we expect them to be (Hazan 2007).

Mindful that the collaboration between museum institutions and communities involves complex processes of boundary crossing and partial connections (Meyer 2010), we will in this paper draw attention towards the cultural heritage communities outside, and interdependent of the museums' institutional frameworks – such as local history organizations and specific interest groups. These communities do represent groups of people that are linked by a shared interest, which collaboratively builds knowledge and negotiates facts about historical artefacts, sites and events outside, but still deeply related to the institutional frameworks that museums and heritage institutions represent.

For example, local history organizations has taken an interesting direction and enhanced their collaboration and dissemination of historical information by social media technologies, and we draw attention to a Norwegian Wikipedia-based (Media WIKI) site for production and sharing of encyclopedic knowledge of local history from numerous municipalities and small towns around Norway. Launched in 2008 the project www.lokalhistoriewiki.no has collected over 8000 articles, and 8500 photos written in collaboration between 700 lay and professional local historians that have registered into the wiki. The project shows that introduction of social networking technologies, such as wiki-platforms, into the cultural heritage field might in some ways give communities a new public space and role and pave the way to new relationships between cultural heritage institutions, public policy and communities (Stuedahl 2009). Virtual communities in the cultural heritage sector are increasingly seen as supplementing institutional knowledge (Affleck and Kvan 2008), and it is imperative that collaborative approaches are explored in a way that allows institutions and communities to work on an increasingly even footing and to augment the leadership role played by community groups when establishing partnerships (Perkin 2010).

Meanwhile involving communities also calls for a deeper understanding of the knowledge building processes that are prevalent and that might affect involvement opportunties. Understanding communities in the heritage sector might need other perspectives and approaches than for example involvement of communities in the public health sector. Also, the notion of involvement of communities need specification; is it part of a trajectory where communities are invited by a museum to collaboratively develop the knowledge base at the museum – including the knowledge frameworks of exhibitions and societal activities, or are communities involved in the collection and documentation activities only. Depending on the level of involvement chosen, different opportunities for collaborative knowledge building and sharing processes between lay contributors and professional opens up. For us it provides an interesting research objects to understand how wiki technology enhances and constrains collaborative activities of collecting and documenting history and categorizing historical sites, artefacts, photos and events.

Communities of practice and epistemic communities in cultural heritage

Communities can be understood as social spaces for the formation of identity, they can be understood as tools in local and national government and they can be understood as a form of social action (Crook 2007). The symbolic, the political and the civic community are each involved in societal and political processes at different levels, and as such determine the type of knowledge building featured by its community engagement. Models of engagement can be highly successful but without caution can also result in unsustainable projects that might erode the trust of communities (Perkin 2010). Thus understanding the character of the community as well as the engagement and processes of knowledge building seems important and requires close analyses.

Communities of practice is "based on a set of relations among persons, activity and world, over time and in relation with other tangential and overlapping communities of practice" (Lave and Wenger 1991:98) and is very much a concept that involves the knowledge production that takes place in an informal setting. In communities of practice members are bound by a collectively developed understanding of what their community is about, and hold each other accountable in a mutual and joint enterprise that has produced a shared repertoire of languages, routines, sensibilities, artifacts, tools, stories, and styles (Wenger 2000) as well as established dynamics of participation and reification that supports the group (Wenger 1998). Being a concept developed for understanding the socio-cultural and collective situatedness of learning it has also been applied to the scientific arena, where for example Kuhn argues that membership in scientific communities is based on the individual researcher accepting to work within a paradigm. (Kuhn 1996).

The notion of community of practice has been used to describe the connections and collaboration between amateurs and professionals related to museums collections, (Meyer 2010 and 2008) and exhibition development (Høg Hansen and Moussouri 2004), arguing that these also consist of partial connections in which participants do not have clearly defined roles. These collaborations are based on enrolment of lay people in the professional knowledge building in museums, and have been used as an example in the discussion of re-thinking science in terms of its relation to the wider society (Meyer 2008).

There are several related concepts of communities that are relevant for an analysis of cultural heritage communities. One is the policy-relevant knowledge in a particular scientific domain denoted by the concept of epistemic communities (Haas 1992), which is used in studies of how scientific communities has brought policy change to a new domain, or in studies of how activist groups and self-help groups are emerging in the health care sector (Akrich 2010). Epistemic communities can also be understood as describing the trajectory of knowledge building in a community of practice in situations where members' knowledge and competencies becomes part of activism and policy related activities. Epistemic communities then can be understood as a network of actors who share policy orientation towards certain

definitions of the problems at stake along with possible ways of solving them and a technical or scientific expertise that forms the argument (Akrich 2010). Epistemic communities can in this way be understood to emerge out of communities of practice.

Collaborations between lay people and professionals has been understood as boundary-work, where the practices of amateurs and professionals are articulated, performed and protected. By protected is meant for example that amateurs collaborate in another time frame than professionals (short term and opportunistic vs. long term as in paid work). Having less time because they take part in their leisure time, amateurs seem to refuse deadlines and devices that bound them to the time regime of museums practices. Amateurs' spatial situatedness is another critical factor as it leads them to located performances by collecting data as based on other criteria than professionals are constrained by (Meyer 2008). When the Museum and community collaborators work together, different spaces, times and practices are therefore brought together – challenging the alignment and enrolment between amateurs and professionals.

Collaborators are peripheral participants (Wenger 1998) and there are multiple, varied, more-or-less-engaged and inclusive ways of being located in the participation (Lave and Wenger 1991, Meyer 2008); "When they do science, where they do science, how they do science and with what tools they do science is what differentiates collaborators from Museum staff members and more generally, amateurs from professionals" (Meyer 2008: 48). There are plenty of opportunities for connection, but the challenge is that there are many connections to be linked, they are often misaligned in time and place, and they tend to be fragile. Care must be taken to align them for successful collaboration that will ensure even participation and constructive knowledge building.

We need deeper studies of how online communities collaborate and build knowledge together, to understand how time, space and materiality might have different shapes and roles in online communities of practice than in collaborations between museums and local communities. Studies of co-construction of knowledge in wikispaces in classrooms suggest that technology are structuring devices that prescribe specific organization and coordination of activities – as well as being mediator of meaning making in novel tasks (Lund and Rasmussen 2008). Wikis provide space for multiple participants to come together and where the presence of others participants are mutually constitutive for the development of knowledge. Focusing on the processes of appropriation (Säljö 2000, Wertsch 1998) as a social and collaborative process, Lund and Rasmussen (2008) suggest a methodological approach for analyzing wiki based learning by studying how knowledge is negotiated and interpreted and how the processes of uptake (Lemke 2000) is proceeded. How are contributions to the wiki made by some made relevant for others, and how is a specific contribution chosen for further development in the ongoing collaborative knowledge building?

Wiki communities - bridging expert and lay knowledge in local history

The Norwegian Institute of Local History is an independent public institution under the Norwegian Ministry of Culture launched the wiki community we are studying in 2008. Funded in 1955, the institute has kept its purpose of promoting local and regional activity through providing services, research and documentation. The institute collaborates closely with The Norwegian Association of Local History, funded in 1920 and established by 421 local history associations – comprising 80.000 individual members of local historians in Norway. The institute focus spans from local historical interest and engagement to professional and academic interest. The institute has relationship with most history departments of universities and colleges in Norway, since staff historians have been engaged in many local history projects. Before the building of the wiki, the publishing of "Bygde"-books, book collections rendering the history of the rural, urban district or town – or the farm and family history accounting for individual farms and families. The "Bygdebok"

publications were financed by public authorities of the municipalities and written by professionals. In addition approximately 300 local history annuals is published every year – where local history amateurs dominate.

The story of how the Norwegian Institute of Local History in several iterations tried to provide technology to enhance community activities informed us that efforts are needed to customize and match technology to actual community needs, ease of use and providing means for learning and development. Already in 2002 they opened a site on the net that originally was thought of as a site that could open up for collaboration with and between different institutions. The initiative was met with low activity and the institute reorganized the site to present the activities of the institute. They started a local history network, to connect people working with writing projects. These projects shared the common need for a methodology and solving practical problems. However, this initiative ended up being one-way interaction; the institute serving the organization and people. Success in the endeavors towards building an online network for local history did first arrive during the re-editing of the Norwegian Historical Lexica in 2004. This led the institute to the idea of using a wiki format for organizing the contents. Today the local history wiki has 3 administrators working with technical solutions, 700 registered users, 19 administrators, 12 supervisors and 22 active users the last days. The local history wiki is driven by a democratic movement that is materialized in an organization that bridges the assemblies of perspectives of local history, memory and genealogy from amateurs and professionals in academia with services and initiatives towards schools and society.

Co-constructing knowledge and categories in cultural heritage

Several studies have shown how digital technologies, rather than merely representing objects open up for the multiplicity of perspectives and understanding that is connected to them on a community or public level. Very early digitization was defined as transformative processes that provided possibilities for revision index, archives and the mediation of cultural heritage (Mannoni 1996). Cultural heritage knowledge has been focused on the material qualities of cultural heritage objects and the categorization used has been weakly questioned (Witcomb 2007). The extended conception of cultural heritage with broadened participation challenges this – and calls for revising the epistemological foundations on which documentation is formulated, as well as to consider how diverse cultural and theoretical ideas might take into account the technological potentialities (Cameron and Robinson 2007). One of the possibilities is for example to connect material and immaterial knowledge objects in digital collections and archives. The status of objects and their authority might in this way be questioned by the inclusion of non-objects and audio-visual technologies (Witcomb 2007) that mediate the multiple knowledge objects and the interpretations related to them.

Reports from projects that involve new communities, such as for example indigenous people clearly show the inadequacy of standard collection documentation (see Verran 2006, 2007; Brown 2007; Witcomb 1997 and 2003; Cameron and Robinson 2007). These studies show how multiple categories can be integrated and play a role for involving new communities in the indexing process. In studies of classification systems outside the cultural heritage field, a more pragmatic view of categories is proposed. By treating categories as working tools, the studies show how understanding of categories might be heterogeneous in that they work as boundary objects. Boundary objects are flexible concepts that build a common framework for defined communities (Bowker and Star 1999; Star 1990, 1995). The development of categories in the cultural heritage field, as well as the role of technology in this context makes an interesting entrance point for understanding the role of technology as tools for reflection and knowledge building in communities of lay people and professionals working towards a common goal.

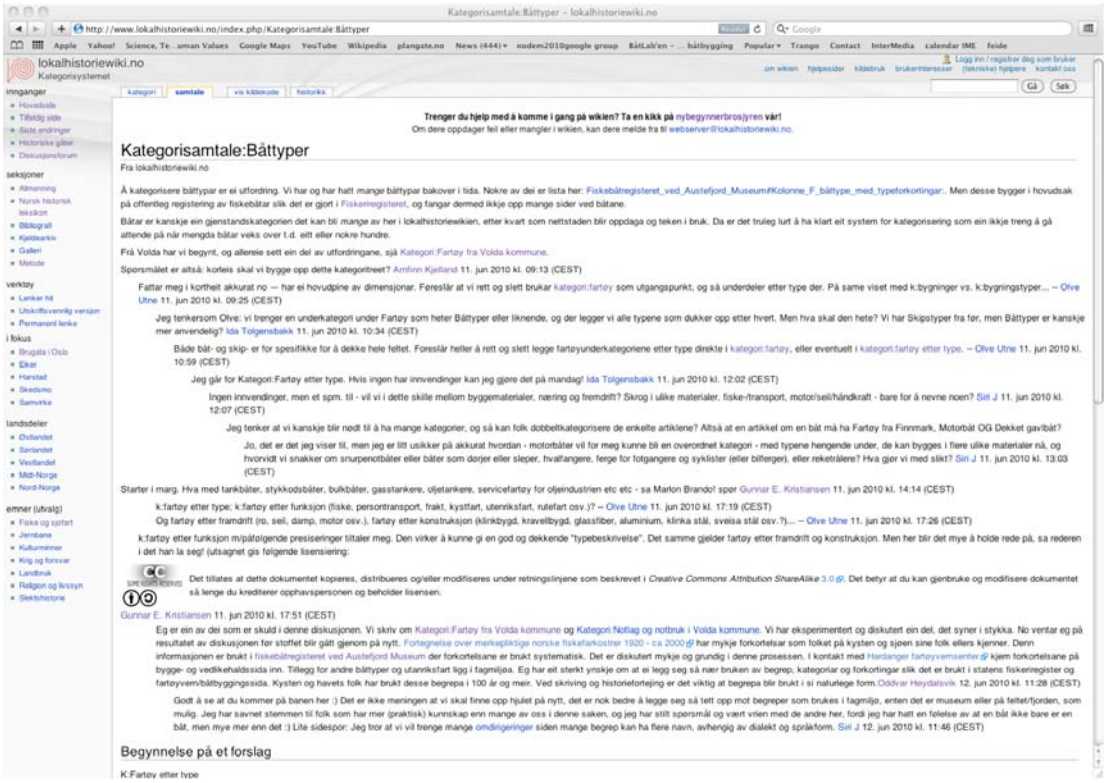


Fig 1. There are several discussions on categories on the local history wiki. One of these is related to categorizing ships and boats.

In order to study how the local history wiki evolves over time, we will here focus on how the co-construction of knowledge takes place in relation to the development of concepts and categories that structures the wiki space. We have chosen an excerpt from the discussion forum that happened during summer 2010. The forum contains a separate discussion thread on categories – in which professionals and lay historians negotiate on the categorization of ships, boats and marine vessels.

The discussion thread started by one of the professional historians during June 2011, claiming that categorizing boat types is challenging because the formal categories are built on categories in the registration systems provided by the Directorate of Fisheries, which does not cover all the historical boats and vessels in the Norwegian tradition. The collaborator (amateur participant) who we have anonymized as AK states that it might be wise to start making a system of categories that does not need to be reorganized in the future. AK informs that a group from the west coast of Norway has started to build a classification system, and provides a hyperlink to the page as a proposal to start the discussion.

Excerpt 1: Request from on collaborator

Å kategorisere båttypar er ei utfordring. Vi har og har hatt *mange* båttypar bakover i tida. Nokre av dei er lista her: Fiskebåtregisteret_ved_Austefjord_Museum#Kolonne_F_båttype_med_typeforkortingar:. Men desse bygger i hovudsak på offentleg registering av fiskebåtar slik det er gjort i Fiskeriregisteret, og fangar dermed ikkje opp mange sider ved båtane.

Båtar er kanskje ein gjenstandskategorien det kan bli *mange* av her i lokalhistoriewikien, etter kvart som nettstaden blir oppdaga og teken i bruk. Da er det truleg lurt å ha klart eit system for kategorisering som ein ikkje treng å gå attende på når mengda båtar veks over t.d. eitt eller nokre hundre.

Frå Volda har vi begynt, og allereie sett ein del av utfordringane, sjå Kategori:Fartøy fra Volda kommune.

Spørsmålet er altså: korleis skal vi bygge opp dette kategoritreet? AK 11. jun 2010 kl. 09:13 (CEST)

The proposal suggested by AK is to follow the structure of the indices that one of the coastal museums and its community had developed for recording fisher boats. This structure contains information about localities in the municipality, formal category, attribute, name of the boat related to operational form, name of type of boat, materials used in construction, building year, size, volume, name, building year of motor, etc. The structure clearly captures both the material and the functional aspects of the boat in question. All in all, the proposal suggested 15 subcategories to categorizing boats.

The administrators of the site immediately responded to the request and initiated a discussion for how the category system could be built in simpler ways. Suggesting that marine vessels might be the main category, and then building subcategories on that basis, the administrator OU tries to keep the amount of categories on a manageable level. After some discussion with his fellow administrators, he suggests to open for categorizing the vessels after type. Then SJ asks how the type of vessels would identify the material character, the function and the use of the vessel. At this point one of the collaborators point to the many vessels that are characterized by their functions (cargo-ships, oil-tanks, service-ships). At the end of the day the administrator OU proposes categorizing vessels by type, function, progress and construction.

Excerpt 2: The administrators responds and discusses the proposal

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(…) Føreslår at vi rett og slett brukar kategori:fartøy som utgangspunkt, og så underdeler etter type der. På same viset med k:bygninger vs. k:bygningstyper...
OU 11. jun 2010 kl. 09:25 (CEST)

Jeg tenkersom Olve: vi trenger en underkategori under Fartøy som heter Båttyper eller liknende, og der legger vi alle typene som dukker opp etter hvert. Men hva skal den hete? Vi har Skipstyper fra før, men Båttyper er kanskje mer anvendelig?
IT 11. jun 2010 kl. 10:34 (CEST)

Både båt- og skip- er for spesifikke for å dekke hele feltet. Foreslår heller å rett og slett legge fartøyunderkategoriene etter type direkte i kategori:fartøy, eller eventuelt i kategori:fartøy etter type. -- OU 11. jun 2010 kl. 10:59 (CEST)
Jeg går for Kategori:Fartøy etter type. Hvis ingen har innvendinger kan jeg gjøre det på mandag!
IT 11. jun 2010 kl. 12:02 (CEST)

Ingen innvendinger, men et spm. til - vil vi i dette skille mellom byggematerialer, næring og fremdrift? Skrog i ulike materialer, fiske-/transport, motor/seil/håndkraft - bare for å nevne noen?
SJ 11. jun 2010 kl. 12:07 (CEST)

Jeg tenker at vi kanskje blir nødt til å ha mange kategorier, og så kan folk dobbeltkategorisere de enkelte artiklene? Altså at en artikkel om en båt må ha Fartøy fra Finnmark, Motorbåt OG Dekket gavlbåt?
Jo, det er det jeg viser til, men jeg er litt usikker på akkurat hvordan - motorbåter vil for meg kunne bli en overordnet kategori - med typene hengende under, de kan bygges i flere ulike materialer nå, og hvorvidt vi snakker om snurpenotbåter eller båter som dørjer eller sleper, hvalfangere, ferge for fotgangere og syklister (eller bilferger), eller reketrålere? Hva gjør vi med slikt?
SJ 11. jun 2010 kl. 13:03 (CEST)

Starter i marg. Hva med tankbåter, stykkodsbåter, bulkbåter, gasstankere, oljetankere, servicefartøy for oljeindustrien etc etc (…)
GE 11. jun 2010 kl. 14:14 (CEST)

k:fartøy etter type; k:fartøy etter funksjon (fiske, persontransport, frakt, kystfart, utenriksfart, rutefart osv.)?
OU 11. jun 2010 kl. 17:19 (CEST)

Og fartøy etter framdrift (ro, seil, damp, motor osv.), fartøy etter konstruksjon (klinkbygd, kravellbygd, glassfiber, aluminium, klinka stål, sveisa stål osv.?)...
OU 11. jun 2010 kl. 17:26 (CEST)

Next day the collaborator OH, who is a member of the user community on the west coast that started the discussion and an active amateur-expert in marine history, poses a new question to the discussion. OH asks to use a structure of categories that are well known and used among people at the coast as well as in maritime communities. He points out that the index used by the Directorate is based on well-known acronyms that has been used for more than 100 years, and integrated in the category system they have developed in collaboration with the coastal museum. He asks if the new category system will be developed in correspondence to those that re well known – because, as he argues, in writing and storytelling it will be important that the concepts are used in their natural form.

Excerpt 3: Answers from collaborators

Eg er ein av dei som er skuld i denne diskusjonen. Vi skriv om Kategori:Fartøy fra Volda kommune og Kategori:Notlag og notbruk i Volda kommune. Vi har eksperimentert og diskutert ein del, det syner i stykka. No ventar eg på resultatet av diskusjonen før stoffet blir gått gjenom på nytt. Fortegnelse over merkepliktige norske fiskefarkostrer 1920 - ca 2000 har mykje forkortelsar som folket på kysten og sjøen sine folk ellers kjenner. Denn informasjonen er brukt i fiskebåtregisteret ved Austefjord Museum der forkortelsane er brukt systematisk. Det er diskutert mykje og grundig i denne prosessen. I kontakt med Hardanger fartøyvernsenter kjem forkortelsane på bygge- og vedlikehaldssida inn. Tillegg for andre båttyper og utanriksfart ligg i fagmiljøa. Eg har eit sterkt ynskje om at ei legg seg så nær bruken av begrep, kategoriar og forkortingar slik det er brukt i statens fiskeriregister og fartøyvern/båtbyggingssida. Kysten og havets folk har brukt desse begrepa i 100 år og meir. Ved skriving og historiefortejing er det viktig at begrepa blir brukt i si naturlege form.
OH 12. jun 2010 kl. 11:28 (CEST)

(thanking OH for participating….). SJ 12. jun 2010 kl. 11:46 (CEST)

Begynnelse på et forslag:
K:Fartøy etter type dampskip-motorbåt-seilbåt-jakt-skonnert-lekter-brønnfartøy-galeas-osv
K:Fartøy etter anvendelse/funksjon fartøy til havfiske-fartøy til fjordfiske-fartøy til kystfiske-fartøy til hvalfangst-losjifartøy-slepefartøy-fartøy knyttet til oljeindustrien-osv
K:Fartøy etter materiale fartøy av tre-fartøy av jern-fartøy av kompositt
og/eller
K:Fartøy etter konstruksjon klinkbygd fartøy-osv
IT 14. jun 2010 kl. 15:31 (CEST)

Nok et innspill, litt omarbeidet etter forrige. Foreslår at begrepet "type" brukes omtrent som "hvordan ser båten ut".
K:Fartøy etter type Gavlbåt, kutter, krysser, jakt, nordmørsbåt, oselvar osv.
K:Fartøy etter anvendelse/funksjon Fiskefartøy (havfiske eller kystfiske - finoppdeling her kan jo diskuteres), ishavsfartøy, fangstfartøy, passasjerfartøy, supplybåt, bilferje, skoleskip, fritidsbåt, handelsreisendebåt, lensmannsbåt osv.
K:Fartøy etter materiale fartøy av tre (trefartøy), fartøy av jern eller stål, fartøy av aluminium osv
K:Fartøy etter konstruksjon klinkbygd fartøy, kravellbygd, klinka stålfartøy, sveist stålfartøy (evt bare stålfartøy?)
K: Fartøy etter rigg Jakt, galeas, skonnert, fullrigger osv
Eks: Dampskipet (D/S) Oster (framdrift) er en kutter (utseende/type) og en passasjerbåt (funksjon).
S/J Mathilde er ei segljakt (framdrift), fraktefartøy (funksjon), hardangerjakt (utseende). Den har jakterigg og jakteskrog. S/G Svanhild er ei jakt med galeasrigg.
Det som ikke kommer med her er de tradisjonelle benevnelsene på åpne båter. Færing, seksæring/treroring/trerøing, åttæring/firroring, fembøring osv. En robåt kan være en hardangeråttæring (utseende/størrelse) og kirkebåt (funksjon). Den kan også være rigget med sprisegl, men dette vil ikke gi båten en benevnelse (i vanlig språkbruk). Dette kan fanges opp i kategorien type (nordlandsfæring) eller eller en kan legge opp til en egen kategori. Men det blir en eksklusiv kategori for denne gruppen av båter (og geografisk knytta til Vest- og Nordnorge).
Dersom en skal kutte ned på kategoriene mener jeg en ikke skal fjerne de to første, da disse er viktige for å forstå den sammenhengen fartøyene har fungert i.
(…) Dette er ikke så lett å manøvrere i, og jeg mener vel i grunnen at det er greit å holde seg til ordboka. Men det kan være greit å avklare dette på et tidlig tidspunkt i denne wiki-diskusjonen.

Hilsen Å

The posting from OH resulted in administrator IT two days later suggests to categorize based on type, function, material and construction. AK who started the discussion thread responded to this, saying this will neglect the traditional open boats of Norwegian maritime history. Å also ends his posting by pointing out that the wiki should develop according to normal thesaurus – and that it is important to clarify this early in the wiki-discussion.

The administrator ask two days after if the categorizing could start on a more basic

level and be extended as they see what needs people in the wiki community have over time. Å answers by asking what it would be fruitful for the wiki when seen in relation to the concepts used by management institutions like the Directorate for Cultural Heritage and The Cultural Heritage Act.

Excerpt 4: Uptake from administrators

Takk, (…)! Jeg tenker at vi kan begynne på en kategorisering som er litt enkel, og så finsortere etter hvert som vi ser hva slags behov folk har. Når det gjelder Skip / Båt / Farkost osv. hadde jeg liksom håpet at Fartøy var et tilnærmet nøytralt begrep. Men det er det kanskje ikke? IT16. jun 2010 kl. 09:01 (CEST)

I ordboka og ofte ellers er det et nøytralt begrep. I muntlig språk har jeg inntrykk av at fartøy ofte er regna som større enn båt. Men samtidig brukes som nevnt over båt og fartøy delvis om hverandre. Forvaltningen (Riksantikvaren) skiller mellom fartøy og båt. Det samme gjør Jon Godal som har skrevet mye om båter. I kulturminneloven er det begrepet BÅT som er brukt som det overgripende begrepet. Hva er hensiktsmessig for denne sammenhengen?

— *Å* (samtale · bidrag) 18. jun 2010 kl. 11:12

The current organization of the wiki provides categories for vessels based on locality, period of time they ere built, and according to boat type.

While the open structure of the wiki platform clearly provides the technological means for negotiations across communities, making visible the multiple contributions, giving access to participate in discussions from multiple viewpoints – it still seems that the administrators are given a priority and authority in that it is their responsibility to find solutions that solves the challenges of establishing a category structure that is simple and easy to use for all – as well as professional enough to provide a conceptual level that makes the wiki specific enough for professional knowledge building.

Discussion

Unlike a forum, participating in a wiki requires that users are registered as individuals with an identity. Without being registered individuals cannot participate in a wiki discussion. Also the wiki-collaboration is based on participants having different roles; the 12 supervisors appointed by the Institute of Local History have the role of checking that the articles meet certain criteria of proficiency. The supervisors have background in history and/or a related field. They can discuss relevance, use of methods and questions related to resources with the authors of the articles, and will check referencing, validity and source criticism related to published articles. In addition there are 19 administrators who have the role of adjusting the wiki technology, helping new users get started and following up on new publications in the wiki. They have access rights to delete or re-publish pages, they can lock pages, they can block individual users, they edit messages and they can import pages from other wikis. As such they have a double role as both technical and administrative gatekeepers, and their boundary work contains both technical and systemic challenges as well as professional evaluations.

In the discussion of categorizing boats, ships and vessels above, we see the importance of administrators (IT, S and OU) and supervisors (AK) in the discussion. We also see how amateur local historians; the collaborators OH, GE and Å participate by providing their knowledge to the discussion. Interestingly, what we do not see in the thread is that collaborators are not peripheral participants; on the contrary they are in the center of the discussion when it comes to negotiating the categorization system to be adopted for the wiki. Being lay people they demonstrate a high level of proficiency, and they also show a level of competency that lean on formal indexical systems used by maritime institutions. The argument of using an existing indexing system because it is well known to people, indicates that the boundary between lay and professional knowledge in this field (Norwegian maritime

history) on this level (categorization) is for practical reasons not important. Rather than observing a boundary between lay and professionals in the categorizing of vessels we observe a boundary between requirements related to the wiki. The role of wiki administrators to keep the number of categories below a complexity threshold is at odds with the shared concerned of collaborators and supervisors to keep the quality of the wiki at a high professional level. As such we need to study the practices of administrators of wiki systems in their effort to align conflicting interests.

Our observation of the negotiation of categories tells us that the notion of community of practice might not be nuanced enough to describe the active participation in knowledge development and policy development for the wiki. The participants in this wiki-thread are well aware that the outcome of the discussion, a new categorization system for articles about marine vessels, will have lasting effect for future publications and to a large extent determine if this wiki will be interesting for coastal historians and historians of coastal culture. Being in a position to have power and take responsibility for the growth of the wiki – the discussion also has a policy orientation. As such the wiki community can be seen as an epistemic community, that has a recognized expertise and competency in a particular domain of interest and an authoritative claim to policy relevant knowledge (Haas 1992). The wiki solution also created another epistemic community, namley the administrators, where normative and principled beliefs (Haas 1992) inform administrators as much as they inform historians. The knowledge building in the local history wiki can thus be understood as being based on negotiating practices related to both the community of historians as well as the community of wikis. In this perspective the negotiation of categories is an epistemic discussion where the outcome will have an impact for the recruitment of new members to the wiki community. It seems plausible to tentatively conclude from our preliminary investigation that epistemic-orineted and practice-driven communities can co-exist in the same environment. At times one of them will be in the foreground, so as when policy discussion are up for stake, and at other times the production of subject-matter articles will be in the foreground. At any time the background may switch to become foreground and vice versa, depending on the need for further publications or reorganization to handle large amounts of articles, etc.

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